chief of R&AW (December 2000 to March 2003), confirms Rao's conciliatory approach, but in critical terms. Apparently Sood, who in 1994 was years away from becoming India's spymaster, had formulated a plan to develop Indian's offensive covert infrastructure in Afghanistan. While the then chief of R&AW supported his plan, Rao refused to give it political clearance.[91] Sood terms Rao's decision-making as 'policy drift … out of indecision' (even though there is emerging literature that credits Rao for taking some of the most audacious and contentious policy decisions that transformed India).[92] Fear of escalating a covert war with Pakistan and balancing domestic civil-military relations are two possible reasons for Rao's aversion to using covert tools of coercion. But there were historical considerations as well. Rao had come to power after an LTTE suicide bomber assassinated his predecessor Rajiv Gandhi, a proponent of coercive diplomacy. Indian intelligence agencies had played a critical role in the Sri Lankan conflict, first to train and equip the LTTE against the Sinhalese-dominated Colombo government, and then to overtly fight against them.[93] Indira Gandhi had also been assassinated by her Sikh bodyguards as a revenge for her decision to deploy the army to flush out Sikh militants from the revered Golden Temple in Amritsar in 1984. Having learnt from the after-effects of employing coercive techniques for political purposes, subsequent Indian PMs, but especially Rao, became wary of resorting to them liberally. Rao's aversion to the use of force was visible in December 1992, when he refused to deploy the army to protect the Babri Masjid despite credible reports that the Hindu *kar-sevaks* would most definitely demolish it.[94] Rao and his successors didn't want to escalate conflict with Pakistan over Kashmir, or in Afghanistan, given India's precarious economic and political situation. Often derogatorily termed as 'lacking political will' (much like the closed border school during the British Raj, which was derided as 'masterly inactivity'), aversion to coercive diplomacy was an important tenet of the conciliators in the 1990s.

Such an approach, however, came under increasing strain as the situation in Kashmir deteriorated, and the Taliban came to power in Kabul. A critical challenge came in mid-May 1995. Haroon Khan, mostly known as 'Major' Mast Gul, who was a Pakistani militant from Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and a senior commander of the Hizb-ul-Mujahideen (HM), entered into a major standoff